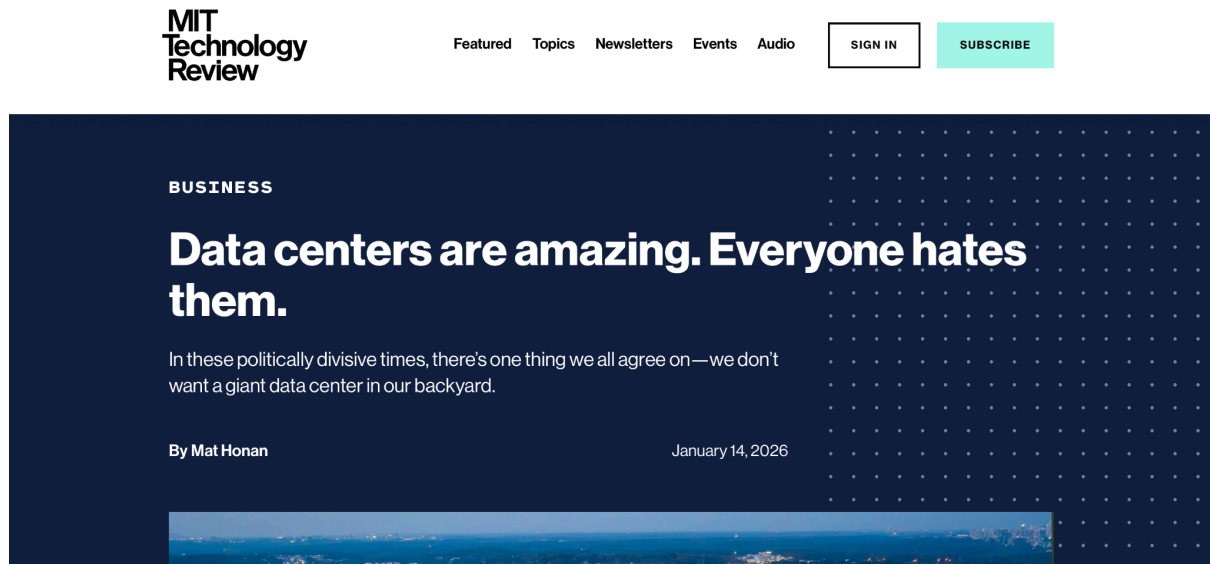


The Local Cost of the AI Data Centre Boom

The article



<https://www.technologyreview.com/2026/01/14/1131253/data-centers-are-amazing-everyone-hates-them/>

This news article: *"Data centers are amazing. Everyone hates them."*, was written by Mat Honan and published on 14-01-2026 in *MIT Technology Review*.

The challenge

Hyperscale data centres deliver benefits that are global or national: compute for AI (and as a consequence, productivity gains for a bunch of people and companies), corporate profit, national economic growth, while imposing costs that are almost entirely local: higher electricity bills as utilities recover grid expansion from all ratepayers, large water use for cooling, constant noise, fossil-fuelled backup generation, and very few permanent jobs once construction ends. This is a rapidly changing situation given improvements in efficiency and similar, but still the issues rises a heated debate among different people and political groups. The conflict is also procedural: incentives are legislated years in advance, zoning often permits the use "by right", and water use is frequently undisclosed, so residents have little say. The result is cross-partisan opposition that is becoming a real constraint on the AI build-out, which slows technological development. Essentially, the problem can be summarised as people in general believe that data centers can provide certain benefits, but don't want them built in their own backyard.

Why we are interested

Our whole degree is sort of Artificial Intelligence, while we had little to no conversation about infrastructure and hardware that is actually needed to make it work. Because of that we did not talk about challenges with that infrastructure as well. This project does not just allow us to understand how the infrastructure work, but also what it's expansion does to society. While most of the buildout is being done in America, it's not a US only issue, Europe also needs it's own AI capabilities, so this issue is applicable to the Netherlands as well

Stakeholders

- **Local residents** (bills, noise, water, property values);
- **Municipal councils and planners** (revenue vs. mandate);
- **Energy regulators and national government** (grid reliability, tariff design);
- **Utilities and grid operators** (cost allocation, stranded-asset risk);
- **Hyperscalers, developers and investors** (permitting, cost of delay);
- **AI users generally**;
- **Competing water and land users** (farms, golf courses, and others)

Scientific literature

**ALL below are original research articles*

A. Rone, J. (2024). The shape of the cloud: Contesting data centre construction in North Holland. *New Media & Society*, 26(10), 5999–6018.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448221145928>

This article explores how local Dutch groups mobilised against the data centers, which is directly relevant to our project, and gives a fresh European example that is close to us.

B. van Es, K., van der Weijden, D., & Bakker, J. (2023). The multifaceted and situated data center imaginary of Dutch Twitter. *Big Data & Society*, 10(1), 1–16.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/20539517231155064>

This article explores the effect of social media in negative image of data centers. Which is related to our project, since a big part of it is perception of data centers

C. Ramos Cáceres, C., Sandberg, M., & Sotoca, A. (2024). Planning data center locations in Swedish municipalities: A comparative case study of Luleå and Stockholm. *Cities*, 150, 105063. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2024.105063>

Compares different municipalities abilities to actually integrate data centers, and related consequences. Which is a great example directly related to the cause of our project.

D. de Vries-Gao, A. (2026). The carbon and water footprints of data centers and what this could mean for artificial intelligence. *Patterns*, 7(1), 101430.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.patter.2025.101430>

Raises interesting points on reporting about actual usage of datacenters by AI, which provides an alternative opinion related to our project topic